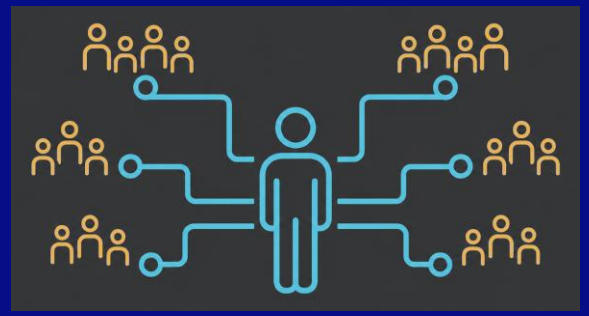
University of Otago
ŌTĀKOU WHAKAIHU WAKA
Te Kura Rorohiko
School of Computing
Te Reo Inarahi me te Mātai Wetereo
English and Linguistics



DHUM101

Socially Responsible Computing

Lecture 5
Needs and Rights of the Individual

- Hunter Hatfield
Semester 2, 2026

Today

- For privacy, we all have our limits
- Is this really an issue?
- Ethical theory: Autonomy, agency, and the categorical imperative
- Applying to technology questions

We All Have Our Limits

We All Have Our Limits

Privacy. We should control facts about ourselves.

Variation. By individual

- Flock – cameras for Automatic License Plate Recognition
- DeFlock – people who actively try to get cameras, some violently

Variation. By society

- Cameras are only in private places
- Some cameras exist in priority areas
- Cameras are almost everywhere

So is privacy made up? Is privacy in the eye of the beholder?

We All Have Our Limits

Privacy. We should control facts about ourselves.

Variation. By individual

Variation. By society

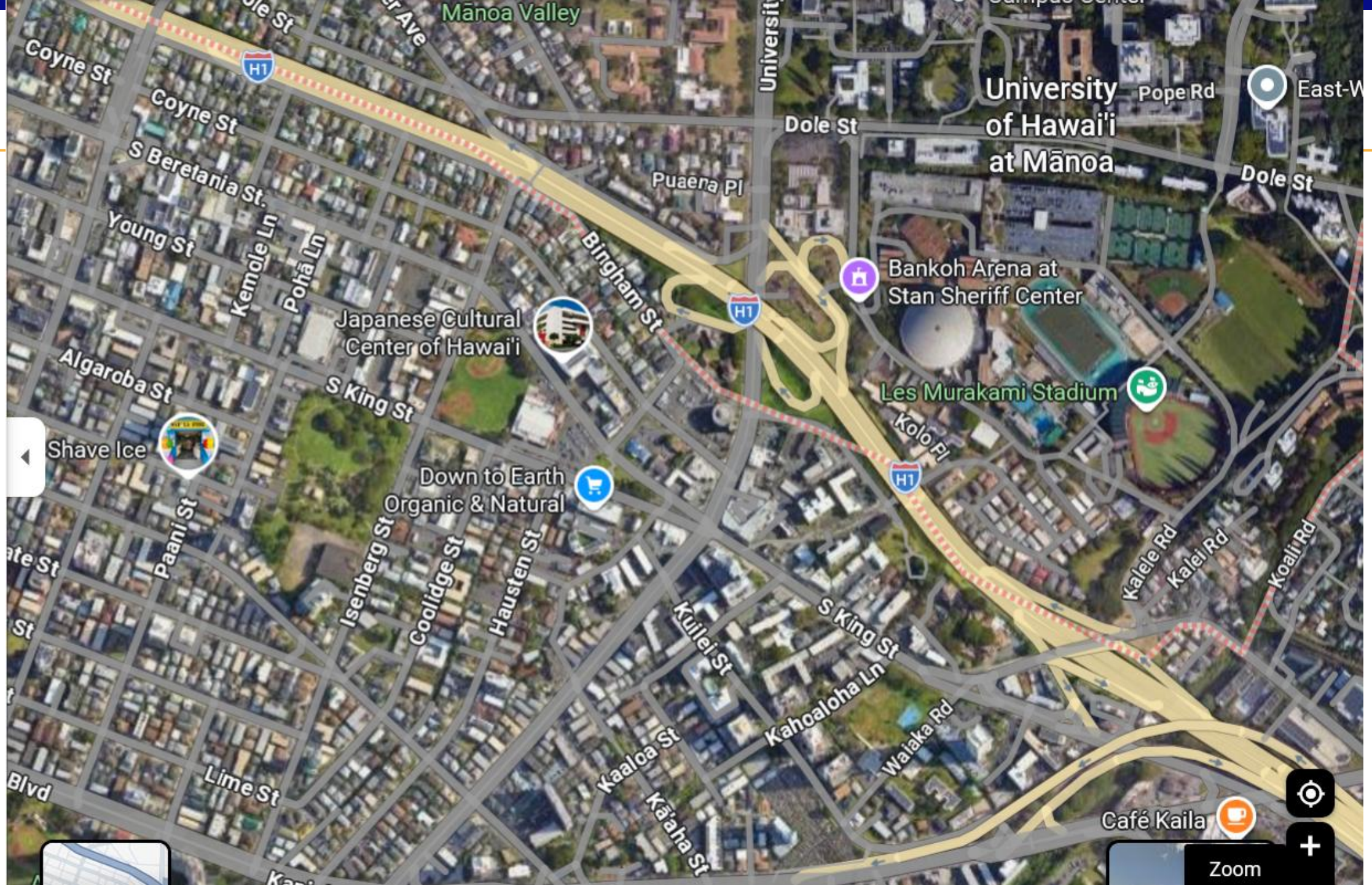
So is privacy made up? Is privacy in the eye of the beholder?

Relevant Tangent

Around 2008, Hawai'i was considering putting in a light rail system that went to the university. Some people objected because they didn't want an ugly rail system marring the neighbourhood






Mānoa Valley
Coyne St
Coyne St
S Beretania St.
Young St
Kemole Ln
Pohā Ln
Bingham St
Puaena Pl
Dole St
University of Hawai'i at Mānoa
Pope Rd
Dole St
East-W
Bankoh Arena at Stan Sheriff Center
Japanese Cultural Center of Hawai'i
Algaroba St
S King St
Les Murakami Stadium
Kolo Pl
Shave Ice
Down to Earth Organic & Natural
Paani St
Isenberg St
Coolidge St
Hausten St
Kuilei St
S King St
Kahoaloha Ln
Waiaka Rd
Kaaloa St
Kā'aha St
Lime St
Kalele Rd
Kalei Rd
Koali Rd
Café Kaila
Zoom


Coolidge St
S King
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We All Have Our Limits

Privacy. We should control facts about ourselves.

Variation. By individual

Variation. By society

So is privacy made up? Is privacy in the eye of the beholder?

The Point

We are used to what we grew up with. It doesn't mean it's right.

We All Have Our Limits

Others watching.

- No cameras in the city?
- No cameras in the street?
- No cameras in the bedroom?
- No cameras in the restroom?
- No cameras in your head?

Is data about my activities public?

- What my job is
- What I watched or read
- What my relationships are
- What my health is

Individual Duties

Privacy. We should control facts about ourselves.

Ownership. I own the data I produce

Agency. The ability to act, make choices and affect the world

Autonomy.

People should be free… to make decisions about their lives without interference, coercion, or manipulation.

The right of competent adults to make informed decisions about their own life and choices and must be able to give consent free from coercion.

Is this really an issue?

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The Brick. https://getbrick.app/products/brick

Flora. https://flora.appfinca.com/

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Flora. https://flora.appfinca.com/

These all suggest that at some level you do NOT have autonomy over your smart phone use

Is this really an issue?

Incogni. https://incogni.com/

VPNs. https://nordvpn.com/

Is this really an issue?

Incogni. https://incogni.com/

VPNs. https://nordvpn.com/

These all suggest that at you do not have control of your data and must pay to restore it

Is this really an issue?

But Wait.

- Didn't we legally consent to how our data is used?
- We have Terms of Service

Discussion

- Did we truly give informed consent to data usage?
- Did we have a choice?

Discussion

- Consider different apps: Can we choose not to use Google? Can we choose not to use a supermarket loyalty card? Can we choose not to use an app for growing digital flowers?

Some Ethical Theory

An Ethical Dilemma

You are a sheriff in an unfortunate town.

- A mob thinks that a man – Randy – has committed a horrible crime.
- They want 'justice'.
- You know that Randy didn't do it but you have no way to convince the mob.
- What do you do?
  - If you turn over Randy, one innocent person will be hurt.
  - If you do NOT turn over Randy, many innocent people will be hurt.
- This sort of thing does happen
- What is the right thing to do?

An Ethical Dilemma

The right choice depends upon the consequences

The right choice depends upon the principles of your action

The Categorical Imperative

How to decide what is not allowed?

- Categorical imperative == A universal command or maxim
- Maxim: Take a goal, something you want to do or accomplish. Strip away all of the details to make it universal. This is a maxim.
- Example: I want to eat lunch.
- Example: I want to sell an app for trading textbooks.

The Categorical Imperative

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- **Maxim: Do Not Use Others as a Mere Means**

The Categorical Imperative

Maxim: Do Not Use Others as a Mere Means

- Means == a method of doing something, like using a tool
- We use people as a means all the time.
  - Paying a cashier at a store
  - Attending class and listening to lecture
- To use them as a MERE means is “to involve them in a scheme of action to which they could not in principle consent.”

The Categorical Imperative

Maxim: Do Not Use Others as a Mere Means

Example 1

- I will promise Randy I will do something without any intention to do it.
- Can Randy agree to this?

The Categorical Imperative

Maxim: Do Not Use Others as a Mere Means

Example 1

- I will promise Randy I will do something without any intention to do it.
- Can Randy agree to this?
- NO
- A promise implies the intention to do something. If Randy knows you will not do it, it is not a promise.
  - Different from you intending to do it and failing.
  - Different from Randy pretending to promise
  - In categorical condition, it results in a contradiction
- Randy cannot consent to it even in principle, so he is reduced to a mere means.

The Categorical Imperative

Maxim: Do Not Use Others as a Mere Means

Steps to Applying

1. Figure out the maxim that the action is based upon
2. Ask if all parties involved could consent to behaviour based upon that maxim

An Ethical Dilemma

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Can the mob-accused Randy agree to this?

An Ethical Dilemma

Discussion Perspective 1

- You can't ignore the consequence! Many people are hurt because of your choice.

Discussion Perspective 2

- This is correct. Just because the mob will do something morally wrong, it doesn't mean you should as well.

The Categorical Imperative

Maxim: Do Not Use Others as a Mere Means

Not Everyone has to agree to everything

- I want to watch a movie
  - No contradiction happens if some disagrees
  - It is possible for someone to consent
- I want to skip lecture
  - No contradiction
  - It may be a bad choice
  - It may hurt you to do it
  - But someone COULD consent to you skipping class.
- The CATEGORICAL imperative forbids the contradictions

The Categorical Imperative

Maxim: Do Not Use Others as a Mere Means

- Is slavery allowed with the categorical imperative?

- Is stealing allowed?

- Is lying allowed?

The Categorical Imperative

Maxim: Do Not Use Others as a Mere Means

- Is slavery allowed with the categorical imperative?
- Is stealing allowed?
- Is lying allowed?

People are not tools.

We are autonomous creatures with our own goals and actions.

We are ends-in-ourselves

If you take away our autonomy, then you are taking away their humanity, their moral dignity.

Applying to Technology

Individual Duties

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Autonomy

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Autonomy

Design a social media app

Is it ethical to make an app that uses psychologically addictive tools?

Why not? Use the steps.

Steps to Applying

1. Figure out the maxim that the action is based upon
2. Ask if all parties involved could consent to behaviour based upon that maxim

Autonomy

Create a Loyalty Card system for a supermarket

Thirty years ago, a person took an item to the cashier, gave cash, and left.

- Date traces are minimal
- No record of the purchase
- No record who purchased
- No record the customer was there except memory

Autonomy

Create a Loyalty Card system for a supermarket

It has changed over the years

- Scanning every single item purchased
- Paying with a card like EFTPOS
- Paying with an app
- A physical card for a loyalty programme
- An app for a loyalty programme
- Biometric facescan as EFTPOS
- https://www.rnz.co.nz/news/business/837139/new-eftpos-terminals-remove-the-need-for-cards-or-phones

Autonomy

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Each of these costs money. Why would a business create them?

Autonomy

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What autonomy risks are there?

Do not forget the assessment due today